him a ‘killer’. The positive agenda of development was forsaken—in every speech Modi now claimed that the Congress had insulted the people of Gujarat. ‘How can a party which can’t act against terrorists talk about us?’ thundered Modi. ‘They call us maut ka saudagar. Tell me, is it a crime to kill a terrorist like Sohrabuddin?’ The reference was to a killing by the Gujarat police that had been labelled a fake encounter. Muslim terrorism, Gujarati pride, Modi as a ‘victim’ of a pseudo-secular elite and the ‘saviour’ of Gujarat—it was almost 2002 all over again.

The election results in December 2007 confirmed that the Congress had self-destructed once again and Modi’s strategy had worked brilliantly. The BJP won 117 seats, the Congress just fifty-nine. Chief minister once again, Modi was now brimming with confidence. ‘*Gujarat ki janta ne mere virodhiyon ko jawab diya hai’* (The people of Gujarat have answered my critics) was his firm response while flashing the victory sign. He was now the unrivalled king of Gujarat. But like all ambitious politicians, he wanted more.

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There are two dates that define Narendra Modi’s twelve-year chief ministership of Gujarat. The first was 27 February 2002—the Godhra train burning and the riots conferred on Modi, for better or worse, the image of a Hindutva icon. The second was 7 October 2008. On that day, the Tata group announced that they would be setting up the Tata Nano plant at Sanand in Gujarat. Its small car project had faced massive opposition over land displacement at its original choice of Singur in Bengal, fuelled by Mamata Banerjee’s Trinamool Congress. Looking for an alternative site, the Tatas plumped for Gujarat as Modi offered them land at a very nominal rate.

That day, Ratan Tata, the Tata chairman, held a joint press conference with Modi. ‘This is an extremely momentous day for us. We have been through a sad experience, but so quickly we have a new home,’ said a delighted Tata, adding, ‘there is a good M (Modi) and a bad M (Mamata)!’